Missouri's Through-Year Testing Program

The Success-Ready Student Assessment (SRSA) and Implications for Tennessee School Districts

Research Report
March 30, 2026

Prepared by Jason Horne

Executive Summary

In July 2025, the U.S. Department of Education approved Missouri as the only state to participate in Round 3 of the Innovative Assessment Demonstration Authority (IADA), launching the Success-Ready Student Assessment (SRSA). This through-year modular testing system replaces the traditional end-of-year Missouri Assessment Program (MAP) with assessments distributed across fall, winter, and spring testing windows in grades 3-8 for ELA and mathematics. The program began piloting in 2025-26 with approximately 5 districts and plans to scale statewide by 2029-30.

The SRSA represents the most ambitious current effort to fundamentally redesign state-level student assessment in the United States. Its key innovations include score banking (students who demonstrate proficiency on a module retain that score), AI-powered scoring with 24-48 hour result turnaround, and explicit support for competency-based education alongside traditional instructional models. Missouri is building on work by the Success-Ready Student Network (SRSN), a coalition of 108+ districts that have been collaborating on assessment reform since 2022.

The evidence base for through-year assessment as an accountability tool is thin. No state has successfully scaled a through-year system statewide with proven comparability to end-of-year tests. The most rigorous meta-analyses find that formative and continuous assessment produces a small but positive effect on student achievement ($d = 0.20$-0.29), substantially smaller than the $d = 0.40$-0.70 commonly cited from older, less rigorous reviews (Black & Wiliam, 1998). The strongest causal evidence, from a cluster randomized trial by Konstantopoulos et al. (2016), shows interim assessments help most in math and for lower-achieving students, with effects of 0.11-0.39 SD depending on grade and subject.

Several states have attempted through-year assessment with mixed results. Nebraska is the only state to fully implement a through-year model statewide (NSCAS Growth with NWEA). New Hampshire's PACE program, the longest-running pilot, showed small positive effects after three years but no significant difference from traditional testing after five years. Georgia withdrew from IADA after its dual-consortium approach fell behind schedule. Texas paused its pilot until 2029. Florida's progress monitoring model did not reduce overall testing burden and was layered on top of existing district assessments.

Tennessee does not currently have a through-year assessment model and has not applied for IADA. TDOE's assistant commissioner explicitly warned against spread-out testing in September 2025, stating that states which attempted it abandoned the practice "because it essentially enforces a statewide version of a pacing calendar, which is wildly unpopular." Tennessee's Joint Advisory Committee on Innovations in K-12 Education is studying assessment reform, with recommendations expected by end of 2025. However, Tennessee already has elements of through-year assessment at the local level through required K-3 universal reading screeners administered three times per year under the Literacy Success Act.

For a district like Greeneville City Schools, which consistently outperforms state averages on TCAP and has seen multi-year proficiency gains of 18-26 percentage points across content areas, the immediate practical implications are limited. Missouri's SRSA is a pilot that will take years to yield outcome data. The stronger near-term action is to monitor Missouri's results, watch for Tennessee legislative action on assessment reform, and ensure that local interim assessment practices (MAP, iReady, or similar) are being used consistently throughout the year, as research shows this is where the instructional benefit lies, regardless of what happens at the state accountability level.

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1. Definition and Background

What Is Through-Year Assessment?

Through-year assessment (also called "through-course" or "year-round" assessment) is a model that distributes state-mandated student testing across multiple windows throughout the school year rather than concentrating it in a single end-of-year summative administration. Instead of one high-stakes test in April or May, students take modular assessments in fall, winter, and spring (or more frequently), with results combined into an annual summative determination of proficiency.

The concept sits at the intersection of several assessment traditions. Formative assessment, which Black and Wiliam (1998) famously described as "inside the black box," provides feedback during learning to guide instruction. Interim or benchmark assessments (MAP Growth, iReady, STAR) are administered periodically to track progress and predict performance. Summative assessments measure achievement at the end of a defined period for accountability purposes. Through-year models attempt to serve all three functions simultaneously, which, as we will see, creates fundamental design tensions.

Missouri's Success-Ready Student Assessment (SRSA)

Missouri's SRSA, approved under IADA in July 2025, is the most recent and arguably most ambitious through-year testing initiative in the country. It replaces the traditional MAP end-of-year test with modular assessments in grades 3-8 for ELA and mathematics.

The program emerged from the Success-Ready Students Work Group (SRSWG), a coalition of 106 stakeholders recruited in 2022, representing 68 unique districts out of Missouri's 554. By late 2024, the Success-Ready Student Network (SRSN) had grown to 108+ districts, with 37 authorized by the Missouri State Board of Education for innovation waivers. Missouri received a $1 million federal Competitive Grant for State Assessments in fall 2024 to fund initial development.

The ELA assessment design (piloting in Grade 4) uses three equivalent parallel test forms administered in fall, winter, and spring windows. Each form covers the full range of Missouri Learning Standards across five modules: Reading, Language, Listening, Research, and Writing. AI scoring provides feedback on reading, listening, and writing modules, with results returned within 24-48 hours. A hierarchical Item Response Theory (IRT) model produces overall scores.

The mathematics assessment (piloting in Grade 5) takes a different approach: 11 cluster assessments of 10 items each, aligned to Missouri Learning Standards clusters, administered as computer-adaptive tests. Students are classified as mastery or not-mastery on each cluster, with pacing requirements of 3 clusters by fall, 7 by winter, and all 11 by spring. An end-of-grade performance task assesses conceptual understanding and mathematical reasoning.

Both designs feature score banking: once a student demonstrates proficiency on a module or cluster, that score is retained and the student is not retested on that content. This is the single

most distinctive feature of the SRSA, designed to reduce redundant testing and support competency-based progression.

Historical Context

Through-year assessment is not a new idea. ESSA, signed in 2015, explicitly authorized states to use "multiple assessments (e.g., curriculum-embedded, interim, or through-course tests) administered throughout the year" as part of their assessment systems. The IADA provision (Section 1204) created a structured pilot pathway for states to develop innovative assessment systems. Six states have been approved: New Hampshire (2018), Louisiana (2018), Georgia (2019, withdrawn), North Carolina (2019), Massachusetts (2020), and Missouri (2025).

The movement gained momentum from frustration with traditional end-of-year testing. Results from spring administrations typically arrive months later, too late for instructional adjustments. The testing window itself can disrupt two to four weeks of instruction. And a single-sitting, high-stakes test creates anxiety that may not reflect students' true capabilities, particularly for lower-achieving students, English learners, and students with disabilities.

2. Evidence of Effectiveness

Meta-Analyses: What the Research Actually Shows

The evidence on formative and continuous assessment has been widely cited but frequently misrepresented. Understanding the actual effect sizes matters for setting realistic expectations about what through-year testing can deliver.

Study	N Studies	Effect Size	Key Finding
Black & Wiliam (1998)	~250 articles	d = 0.40-0.70	Broad review; low-attaining students benefited most
Hattie (2009)	800+ meta-analyses	d = 0.90	Formative evaluation ranked 3rd of 138 interventions
Kingston & Nash (2011)	13 studies	d = 0.20	Only 13 of 300+ candidates met inclusion criteria
Lee et al. (2020)	33 studies	d = 0.29	US K-12 specific; medium-cycle assessments most effective
Yan et al. (2024)	118 studies, 258 ESs	Hedges' g = 0.25	Most comprehensive recent meta-analysis

The pattern is clear: earlier, less rigorous reviews (Black & Wiliam, Hattie) reported large effects (d = 0.40-0.90), while more recent, methodologically rigorous meta-analyses consistently find smaller effects (d = 0.20-0.29). Kingston and Nash (2011) is particularly telling: of 300+ candidate studies, only 13 met basic inclusion criteria for rigorous research design. A 2024 systematic review of 13 meta-analyses found that the robustness of evidence was "very low" in 9 of 13 reviews. The best available evidence suggests formative and continuous assessment produces a small but positive effect on student achievement, not the transformative impact sometimes claimed.

Strongest Causal Evidence

Konstantopoulos, Li, Miller, and van der Ploeg (2016) conducted a cluster randomized controlled trial in 57 Indiana schools with approximately 25,000 students, testing mCLASS (K-2) and Acuity (3-8) interim assessments. This is one of the strongest causal studies in the field. In math (grades 3-8), they found consistent positive effects across the achievement distribution, with the strongest effects at the 10th percentile (~0.20 SD) and Grade 5 effects of 0.25-0.39 SD. In reading, significant effects appeared only at the 10th percentile (~0.11 SD) with minimal effects elsewhere. K-2 findings were minimal and non-significant.

McClure (2025) analyzed Utah's statewide benchmark module data using fixed effects regressions across grades 3-8 from 2020-2023. The key finding: most teachers only used benchmark modules right before the summative exam, producing negligible effects. However,

when modules were assigned regularly throughout the year, students scored higher on end-of-year state exams. This reinforces that implementation fidelity is the critical variable, not the assessment design itself.

Testing Frequency: Diminishing Returns

Bangert-Drowns, Kulik, and Kulik (1991) meta-analyzed 35 studies on classroom testing frequency and found an overall effect of d = 0.23. Critically, they found that achievement gains decreased as the number of tests increased, particularly for longer tests. When tests were used diagnostically with remedial support, benefits were greater. This suggests an optimal testing frequency exists, and more testing is not automatically better. The finding has direct implications for through-year models: if multiple assessment windows simply mean more testing without changed instructional practice, the benefit may be negligible or even negative.

Through-Year Assessment as Accountability: No Proven Models

No head-to-head randomized controlled trial has compared through-year assessment to end-of-year testing for state accountability purposes. The IES evaluation of IADA states (NCEE 2023-004) found that after 2-3 years, IADA systems had made "limited progress" and may not be on track to meet the 5-year statewide scale-up goal. The evaluation reported no student achievement outcome data. New Hampshire's PACE, the longest-running pilot, showed small positive effects after three years but no significant difference from traditional testing after five years (Dadey & Gong, 2023). Georgia withdrew from IADA. No through-year system has been implemented statewide with results accepted as comparable to end-of-year summative scores.

3. Federal and State Policy Context

Federal Framework: ESSA Creates the Opening

ESSA (2015) requires annual statewide assessments in reading/language arts and mathematics in grades 3-8 and once in high school, with at least 95% participation for all students and subgroups. Critically, ESSA does not mandate that annual assessments be a single end-of-year test. Section 1111(b)(2)(H) explicitly permits "multiple assessments (e.g., curriculum-embedded, interim, or through-course tests) administered throughout the year," provided they collectively produce a valid, reliable annual proficiency determination.

The Innovative Assessment Demonstration Authority (IADA), created by ESSA Section 1204, provides the primary pathway for states to pilot through-year systems. IADA allows up to 7 states a demonstration period of up to 5 years (with possible 2-year extension) to develop innovative assessment systems with temporary flexibility from certain requirements. States must demonstrate validity, reliability, comparability across demographic groups, and maintain disaggregated reporting. Six states have been approved to date.

State	Year	System	Design Type	Status
New Hampshire	2018	PACE	Competency-based performance tasks	Operational (~20 districts)
Louisiana	2018	LEAP Through-Year	Curriculum-embedded, 3 windows	Active development
Georgia	2019	MAP/Navvy	Through-year (dual consortia)	Withdrawn from IADA
North Carolina	2019	NCPAT	Through-year, personalized	Active
Massachusetts	2020	Science performance tasks	End-of-year, multiple components	Active
Missouri	2025	SRSA	Through-year modular	Pilot (2025-26)

The Trump administration has signaled strong support for state assessment flexibility. A July 29, 2025 Dear Colleague letter encouraged states to request ESEA waivers under Section 8401, and Oklahoma has requested the most aggressive waiver: permission to switch to through-year testing AND allow districts to choose their own assessments without federal peer review. The current policy environment is the most favorable for through-year assessment innovation since ESSA's passage.

IDEA and Equity Guardrails

Both ESSA and IDEA require all students with disabilities to be included in state assessments with appropriate accommodations. Through-year models raise specific considerations: IEP teams must determine accommodations for each testing occasion, not just one. The 1%

statewide cap on alternate assessments applies regardless of format. Assessment systems must demonstrate that multiple testing windows do not create disparate impact on protected groups, and accommodations must be consistently available across all windows. OCR's civil rights protections, including Title VI, Title IX, and Section 504, cannot be waived under any circumstances.

Tennessee's Assessment Landscape

Tennessee does not currently have a through-year assessment model and has not applied for IADA. The state's assessment system centers on TCAP, a traditional end-of-year summative administered in a concentrated April-May window. TDOE has been explicit in its skepticism: Assistant Commissioner David Laird told the Joint Advisory Committee on Innovations in K-12 Education in September 2025 that states which attempted spread-out testing abandoned it "because it essentially enforces a statewide version of a pacing calendar, which is wildly unpopular in a lot of places."

The 2025 legislative session made assessment policy a flashpoint. The House and Senate disagreed significantly, with the House pushing to reduce testing requirements and the Senate defending the current system. The compromise was HB0675, creating a Joint Advisory Committee to study assessment and teacher evaluation systems, with recommendations due by end of 2025. Teachers testified about scheduling upheaval and student stress during the two-week TCAP window, with at least one educator (Dr. Kevin Schaaf, MNPS) proposing splitting TCAP into three parts throughout the year.

Tennessee already has through-year assessment elements at the local level: K-3 universal reading screeners are required three times per year under the Literacy Success Act, and districts widely use interim assessments (MAP, iReady, STAR) for screening and progress monitoring. TDOE provides optional start-of-year checkpoints and a formative assessment platform (Schoolnet). But these are used locally for instructional decisions, not state accountability.

Changing Tennessee's assessment model would have cascading effects. TISA's outcomes funding is tied to TCAP results. TVAAS requires consistent year-to-year summative data to calculate teacher growth scores, with 35% of teacher evaluations based on student growth measures. The Advisory Committee is studying both assessments and evaluations together, acknowledging they are inextricably linked.

4. What Works: Implementation Models

Missouri SRSA: The Most Detailed Blueprint

Missouri's IADA application provides the most comprehensive implementation blueprint available for through-year assessment. The five-year rollout plan moves from small-scale pilot (Year 1, ~5 districts, ~100 students per grade) to full statewide implementation (Year 5, all 554 districts, ~65,000 students per grade). Districts must meet readiness criteria across five domains: instructional readiness, data use capacity, assessment infrastructure, staff commitment, and instructional leadership.

Year	School Year	Scale	Students/Grade	Key Activities
1	2025-26	~5 LEAs	~100	Small-scale pilot Gr 4 ELA, Gr 5 Math; vendor RFP
2	2026-27	10-15 LEAs	~3,000	Limited pilot; item development grades 3-8
3	2027-28	~50 LEAs	10,000-15,000	Operational field test Gr 4-5; pilot other grades
4	2028-29	Statewide field test	~65,000	All grades 3-8; accountability alignment
5	2029-30	Full statewide	~65,000	Full operational administration

The SRSA supports three instructional models simultaneously: traditional (seat-time based), competency-based (mastery-focused, students advance when proficient), and hybrid (traditional scope with readiness-based acceleration). This flexibility is enabled by Missouri statute Section 161.380, which authorizes competency-based learning frameworks. Professional development is delivered through 9 Regional Professional Development Centers (RPDCs), a model that specifically addresses rural and dispersed district access.

Nebraska NSCAS Growth: The Only Statewide Implementation

Nebraska is the only state to fully implement a through-year model statewide. NSCAS Growth, built on NWEA's through-year assessment platform, replaced both the interim MAP Growth and the summative NSCAS General test beginning in 2022-23. The system administers adaptive assessments in fall, winter, and spring for grades 3-8 in ELA, mathematics, and science. It measures both growth and grade-level proficiency, eliminating the need for separate interim and summative tests. The statewide contract with NWEA is valued at approximately $29 million.

Montana MAST: Short Testlets, Rapid Scaling

Montana's MAST (Montana Aligned to Standards Through-Year) uses a distinctive design: 5 testlets of approximately 15 minutes each throughout the year, developed by New Meridian.

The model scaled rapidly from ~4,400 students in 67 schools during the 2022-23 pilot to ~20,700 students in 129 schools for the 2023-24 field test. Montana received a rare federal field-testing flexibility waiver in August 2023. The short-testlet design is less disruptive to instruction than longer testing sessions and has shown the ability to work across Montana's many small and rural districts.

What Doesn't Work

Curriculum-anchored approaches are hard to scale. Louisiana's model ties assessments to specific curricula (initially ELA Guidebooks 2.0), but implementation varies in pacing and unit selection even among districts using the same materials. Georgia's dual-consortium approach (MAP Partnership plus Navvy) added complexity and split focus; both fell behind schedule and Georgia withdrew from IADA. Requiring fundamental instructional changes alongside assessment changes, as Georgia's Navvy system did, proved too much for districts to absorb at once.

Dual testing during pilots is consistently problematic. Texas's TTAP does not eliminate the obligation to administer STAAR, so pilot districts run both systems simultaneously, increasing rather than decreasing the testing burden. The Bellwether four-state study (Delaware, Florida, Nebraska, Texas) found that districts continued administering interim tests on top of through-year assessments in all four states. The promised testing reduction does not materialize during pilot phases.

Cross-State Comparison

State	Program	Windows/Year	Status	Scale
Missouri	SRSA	3	Pilot (2025-26)	5 LEAs, scaling to statewide by 2029-30
Nebraska	NSCAS Growth	3	Full statewide	All districts
Montana	MAST	5 testlets	Transitioning statewide	54+ districts
New Hampshire	PACE	Multiple	Operational	~20 districts
Louisiana	LEAP TY	3	Active development	Limited districts
Texas	TTAP	3	Paused until 2029	~90 districts
Georgia	MAP/Navvy	Varies	Withdrawn	N/A

5. Cost-Benefit Analysis

Missouri SRSA Costs

Missouri's Year 1 SRSA budget is $1,140,000, including $120,000 for psychometric and data services, funded primarily through a $1 million federal Competitive Grant for State Assessments. Year 1 covers planning, vendor procurement, initial item development, stakeholder engagement, and limited pilot design. Detailed per-pupil cost data is not yet publicly available since the program just began piloting.

Assessment Platform Costs

Platform	Component	Est. Cost/Student/Year	Notes
iReady	Diagnostic only	~$6/subject	Minimum 150 licenses
iReady	Diagnostic + Instruction	~$30-34/subject	Volume discounts available
NWEA MAP Growth	Full suite	Custom (not public)	Includes scoring, reporting, PD
NWEA (Nebraska)	Statewide contract	~$29M total	Statewide for all tested grades
SBAC Basic	Summative only	$22.50/student	$6.20 consortium + $16.30 state
SBAC Complete	Summative + interim	$27.30/student	$9.55 consortium + $17.75 state

The national average for state assessment primary contracts is approximately $27 per student (Brookings estimate), while full assessment spending across all tests averages approximately $65 per student. Through-year models have the potential to consolidate costs if they eliminate separate interim/diagnostic purchases ($6-34/student/year for platforms like iReady or MAP Growth) and separate summative test purchases ($20-30/student/year). However, this consolidation has not been demonstrated at scale.

Hidden Costs

The AFT estimates that when factoring in teacher salary time, test prep, and instructional disruption, true testing costs can reach $848-$1,792 per student (Nelson, 2013). Teachers spend approximately twice the actual student testing time on testing-related activities (e.g., 27.7 hours of teacher time vs. 13.7 hours of student testing time in 3rd grade). Through-year models may reduce this if they eliminate separate test-prep cycles, but may increase it if each testing window triggers its own prep cycle.

Montana's experience illustrates the instructional time concern: the through-year model used approximately 10 testing days across the year versus 4 days for end-of-year testing (Ravalli Republic), and Montana educator feedback indicated significant difficulty aligning testing windows with planned curriculum. Technology maintenance costs are also higher because sustained device readiness is required across 3+ testing windows rather than one.

Potential Savings

If a through-year assessment eliminates the need for separate diagnostic/interim benchmarks, districts could save $6-34 per student per year on those platforms. If it also replaces the state summative test purchase, an additional $20-30 per student could be saved. Faster results (24-48 hours vs. months) reduce the need for separate local data collection. However, ESSER funds that many districts used to purchase assessment platforms have expired, creating a funding cliff that makes any transition more costly in the near term.

6. Criticisms, Limitations, and Risks

The Fundamental Design Tension

The Center for Assessment (NCIEA) identifies a logical contradiction at the heart of through-year assessment systems. For summative/accountability use, the system assumes the student does not change significantly between assessment and year-end. For instructional use, the system explicitly expects students to improve before year-end. These purposes are "logically opposed to each other." Assessment scholars including Dylan Wiliam have argued that formative and summative assessment are so different that the same system cannot fulfill both functions, with formative assessment being "driven out" by summative demands when they coexist.

Missouri-Specific Criticism

Missouri's SRSA faces bipartisan Senate opposition to the related A-F school grading plan, which relies heavily on test scores. State senators from both parties argue the system "focuses only on teaching to the test" and "doesn't give the full picture of what schools are really dealing with." Both the Missouri NEA and Missouri State Teachers Association oppose systems that rely heavily on student test scores. A parent opt-out movement in St. Louis predates the through-year proposal, and 20 districts had previously sought exemption from the Missouri Assessment Program, indicating deep dissatisfaction with the existing testing regime.

Testing Burden: More, Not Less

FutureEd (2024) found it is "not clear that through-year assessments will lead to less testing time overall." The Bellwether four-state study found that districts in Delaware, Florida, Nebraska, and Texas continued administering interim tests on top of through-year assessments, making the testing burden additive rather than a replacement. Florida's FAST model is the most documented example: students in grades 3-10 now take three statewide assessments each in ELA and math (six total), layered over pre-existing district progress monitoring exams. FairTest states directly: "There is no actual evidence that through-year assessments provide educators with more usable, timely information."

Student Impact

Research consistently finds that 10-40% of all students experience some level of test anxiety (Edutopia; ERIC). Harvard GSE research (2019) found students had 15% more cortisol the homeroom period before a standardized test than on days with no high-stakes testing. Through-year models multiply these stress points from one per year to three or more. Young students experience "anxiety, panic, irritability, frustration, boredom, crying, headaches, and loss of sleep" during high-stakes tests. If through-year testing transforms test prep from a seasonal activity to a year-round one, an EdWeek survey (2023) found that 36% of educators report test prep already consumes "pretty much the entire school year" under current systems.

Equity Concerns

Students from low-income backgrounds experience significantly more learning loss on MAP assessments, particularly in ELA, meaning through-year testing may repeatedly measure and highlight disadvantage without providing resources to address it. Georgia's experience showed participation rates dropped to as low as 15% in the highest-poverty districts. Schools in high-poverty neighborhoods lack the human and material resources to translate assessment data into instructional changes, turning data into burden without benefit. ELL students face compounded disadvantage when tested more frequently in a language they are still acquiring. When regression-based methods handle missing data, there is evidence of differential performance based on student race, ethnicity, and school poverty (IES research).

Adaptive Testing for Accountability: A Contested Choice

Using adaptive tests like MAP Growth for high-stakes accountability raises concerns. A Virginia validation study found MAP Growth assessments "do not assess the full range of SOL content, nor do they assess at the highest levels of cognitive demand." Adaptive tests give different students different items, which conflicts with the expectation that a "fair" test gives everyone the same items. Disability rights advocates warned that adaptive testing could repeat pre-NCLB patterns of giving students below-level tests and calling them proficient. Jon Cohen of the American Institutes for Research criticized "a big push from test vendors selling adaptive tests that are not tied to a strong testing blueprint" as "a step backwards."

Conflicting Findings Flag

The research base contains significant internal contradictions. Black and Wiliam (1998) reported effect sizes of 0.40-0.70 for formative assessment, while Kingston and Nash (2011) found only 0.20 using stricter inclusion criteria. Hattie (2009) ranked formative evaluation at $d = 0.90$, but Yan et al. (2024) found $g = 0.25$ across 258 effect sizes. Phelps (2019) reported $d = 0.84$ for frequency + stakes + feedback combined, but acknowledged lower effects for K-12 versus postsecondary settings and for randomized studies. These discrepancies reflect differences in study quality, inclusion criteria, and how "formative assessment" is defined. Decision-makers should rely on the more rigorous recent estimates ($d = 0.20$-0.29) rather than the headline-grabbing larger figures.

7. Measurable Outcomes

Through-year assessment proponents claim several measurable benefits. Here is each claim alongside the strength of the supporting evidence.

Claimed Outcome	Evidence Strength	Key Finding
Improved student achievement	Moderate	d = 0.20-0.29 in rigorous meta-analyses; positive but modest
Benefits for low-achieving students	Moderate-Strong	Konstantopoulos RCT: effects strongest at 10th percentile
Faster instructional feedback	Strong (face validity)	24-48 hour results vs. months for traditional; no outcome study
Reduced testing burden	Weak	Bellwether: districts added tests; Florida FAST increased testing
Improved teacher data use	Weak	No controlled studies; implementation quality is key mediator
Support for CBE	Theoretical	Score banking enables mastery-based progression; no outcome data
Lower test anxiety	Unproven	Multiplies test occasions; may increase rather than decrease stress
Improved equity outcomes	Weak-Mixed	Potential benefits for low achievers; participation gaps in high-poverty
Cost savings	Weak	Consolidation potential exists but not demonstrated at scale

The most consistently supported finding is that formative and interim assessment benefits lower-achieving students the most. This finding appears across multiple meta-analyses and in the Konstantopoulos RCT. However, this benefit depends on what teachers do with the data, not on the assessment structure itself. McClure (2025) found that benchmark modules only improved outcomes when used consistently throughout the year, not when crammed before testing. Implementation fidelity is the critical variable.

New Hampshire's PACE provides the longest-running outcome data for a through-year pilot. After three years, small positive effects were observed across grades 8 and 11 in ELA and math, with lower-achieving students showing small positive differential effects. After five years, however, there was no significant difference between PACE and non-PACE schools. This trajectory, initial positive effects that fade over time, should temper expectations about long-term impact.

A competency-based education study (IES) found that math competency scores accurately predicted state test proficiency for only 40% of students, and literacy competency scores for 59%. Competency scores had statistically significant but weak relationships with state test

scores (R-squared = 0.03-0.04). However, students below grade level completed their level faster: 43-47% finished in 3 or fewer quarters versus 17-22% in traditional systems.

8. Bottom Line

Missouri's SRSA is an ambitious and well-designed pilot that addresses real frustrations with traditional end-of-year testing: delayed results, single-sitting high-stakes pressure, and disconnection from daily instruction. The score banking mechanism, AI-powered rapid feedback, and support for competency-based education represent genuine innovations in state assessment design. Missouri has also done the stakeholder engagement work, with 108+ districts participating in the SRSN and a detailed five-year implementation plan. If any through-year system can succeed, Missouri has put itself in a strong position.

But the evidence demands caution. No state has scaled a through-year assessment statewide with proven comparability to traditional tests. The best research shows formative assessment produces modest achievement effects (d = 0.20-0.29), not the transformative impact sometimes claimed. New Hampshire's positive results faded after five years. Georgia withdrew from IADA. Florida's model increased rather than decreased testing. The fundamental tension between formative and summative purposes remains unresolved in every implementation. And the hidden costs, from teacher time to technology infrastructure to dual-testing during pilots, are real and underappreciated.

For Tennessee, and specifically for Greeneville City Schools, the immediate implications are observational, not operational. TDOE has explicitly pushed back on spread-out testing. The Joint Advisory Committee is studying assessment reform but has not recommended a through-year model. TISA's outcomes funding and TVAAS teacher evaluations are built on the current TCAP framework, and changing either would require careful recalibration. GCS already outperforms state averages by significant margins (9.7-19.7 percentage points across subjects), so the case for disrupting a working system is not urgent.

The recommended next steps for a district like GCS are practical. First, monitor Missouri's SRSA pilot results as they emerge over the next 2-3 years, looking specifically for achievement outcome data, not just implementation milestones. Second, ensure that local interim assessments (MAP, iReady, or similar) are being used consistently throughout the year with clear protocols for data-to-instruction cycles, as this is where the research shows the real benefit lies. Third, track Tennessee's Advisory Committee recommendations and any legislative action on assessment reform in the 2026 session. Fourth, if through-year assessment gains traction nationally, investigate Nebraska's NSCAS Growth as the only proven statewide model and evaluate whether the NWEA through-year platform could integrate with existing GCS assessment practices.

The questions that remain unanswered are significant. Can score banking produce valid, comparable accountability scores? Does through-year testing actually reduce the overall testing burden, or does it just redistribute and potentially increase it? What happens to teacher evaluation models built on end-of-year growth scores when the data inputs change? And most importantly: does any of this improve student learning more than simply using existing interim assessments well? Missouri will begin to answer these questions. Tennessee should watch carefully, but there is no reason to act before the evidence arrives.

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Appendix A: Tennessee Data

Greeneville City Schools 2024-25 TCAP Results

Subject	GCS Proficiency	State Average	Difference
ELA (Grades 3-8)	48.6%	38.9%	+9.7 pp
Math (Grades 3-8)	49.0%	42.2%	+6.8 pp
Social Studies (Grades 6-8)	64.9%	49.0%	+15.9 pp
English II EOC	74.0%	54.3%	+19.7 pp
English I EOC	43.7%	39.2%	+4.5 pp

Over four years, GCS proficiency increased approximately 19 percentage points in ELA, 20 in math, 18 in science, and 26 in social studies. GCS outperforms state averages in every content area.

Tennessee vs. Missouri: Assessment Model Comparison

Feature	Missouri (SRSA Pilot)	Tennessee (TCAP)
Model	Through-year modular (IADA pilot)	Traditional end-of-year summative
Administration	Minimum 3 occasions per year	Single testing window (April-May)
Teacher Flexibility	Choose when to administer modules	Fixed state testing windows
Score Reporting	24-48 hours	Months later (summer release)
Federal Authority	IADA approved for 2025-26	No IADA application
Score Banking	Students can bank proficiency scores	No equivalent
CBE Support	Supports competency-based frameworks	Traditional standards-based
Status	Pilot (select districts, 2025-26)	Fully operational statewide

Tennessee Assessment Policy Timeline (2025-26)

Date	Event	Details
May 2025	HB0675 passed	Created Joint Advisory Committee on Innovations in K-12 Education
Sept 2025	Advisory Committee hearing	TDOE warns against spread-out testing; teachers testify on TCAP burden
Late 2025	Committee recommendations due	Studying both assessments and teacher evaluations
Spring 2026	SB1585 advances	Would allow voucher schools to use national tests instead of TCAP
Spring 2027	Elementary TCAP online	Elementary TCAP migration to online administration begins

Tennessee Local Assessment Landscape

While Tennessee does not have a through-year state assessment, districts already administer interim assessments throughout the year. K-3 universal reading screeners are required three times per year (fall, winter, spring) under the Literacy Success Act. Approved screeners include MAP, iReady, STAR, and others. Students scoring at or below the 15th percentile receive Home Literacy Reports. TDOE provides optional start-of-year checkpoints and the Schoolnet formative assessment platform for teacher-created assessments.

TISA and Assessment Accountability Connection

Tennessee's Investment in Student Achievement (TISA) formula includes outcomes funding tied to TCAP results. Districts must submit annual accountability reports including plans to achieve 70% or more of 3rd graders scoring "met expectations" or "exceeded expectations" on TCAP ELA. Changing the assessment model would directly impact TISA accountability metrics, outcomes funding calculations, and TVAAS growth scores that comprise 35% of teacher evaluations.